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Day 4 of the 12 Days of Madness analytics series: Turnovers and Blocks.

It's often said that limiting and forcing turnovers is key.

I looked at every Tournament from 2008-2025 to see when turnovers and blocks actually changes bracket outcomes.

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Metrics used include:
-`TOR` = offensive turnover rate.
-`TORD` = defensive turnover rate forced.
-`BLK%` and `BLKED%` are the block rates on each side.

All sourced from barttorvik.com

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As usual, lets look at the trends of TO's and blocks over time for anything interesting.

Here we see TO rate on a continued steady decline, while blocks are becoming more frequent.



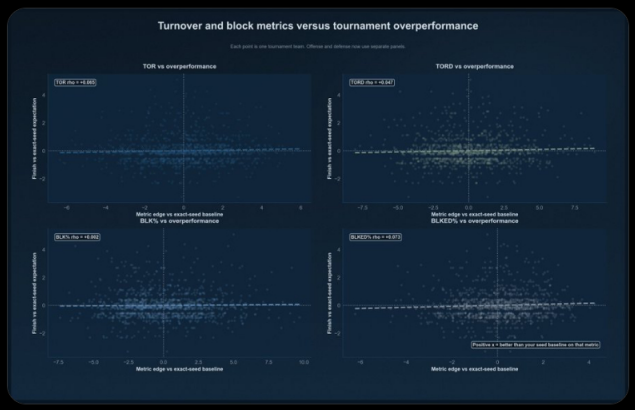
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Next, looking at how these stats relate to March overperformance after controlling for seed:

Turnover management carries over on both offense and defense.

The effect of Block rate is basically zero, while avoiding blocks is the strongest signal of the 4.



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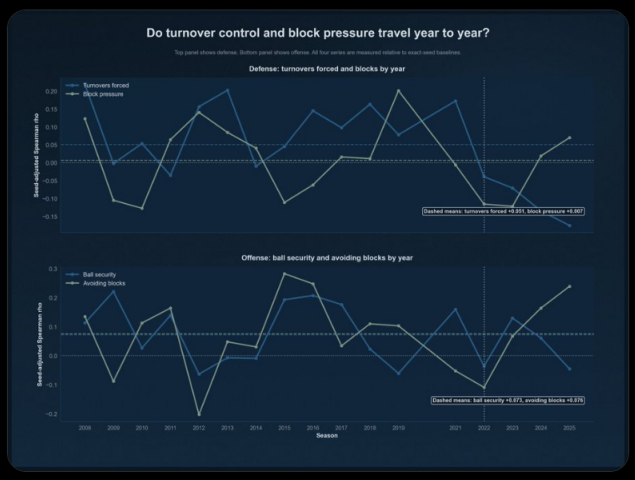
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On the defensive side we see turnovers forced being the stronger signal throughout the sample but trending down in recent years. While the effect of blocks is trending up.

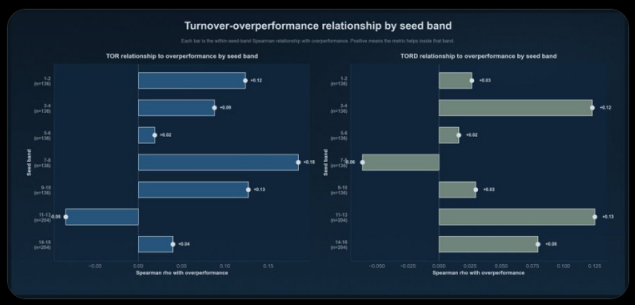
On the offensive side, both are consistently positive indicators of overperformance.



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When looking at success in March across seed lines, we consistently see managing turnovers to be a positive. Only one seed group on the offensive and defensive sides shows up negative. Thus we can accept this as a general trend.

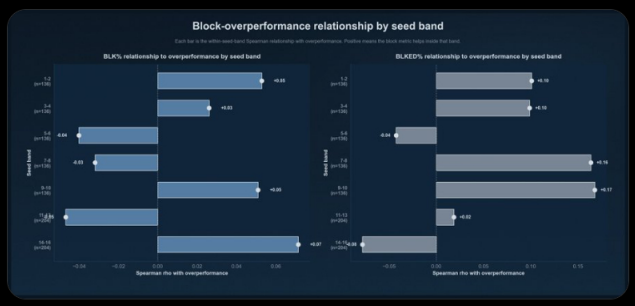


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As we saw before the trend of blocks is inconsistent, including across seed groups.

Whereas the teams that avoid blocks seem to benefit across seed lines for the most part.



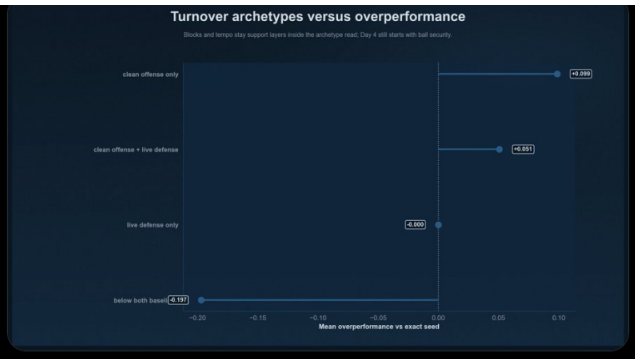
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Teams with low TOs on offense tend to overperform, including when they also force TOs at a high rate.

Teams that only force turnovers well, without limiting them on offense, don't perform better or worse.

Teams that can't force or prevent TOs tend to struggle.



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This view would suggest that forcing turnovers is more important than limiting them, when predicting who will win it all.

Interestingly, there don't appear to be any champs who played an exceptionally low TO style. This could hurt HOU, Illinois, Bama, Arkansas, Wisco.



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That feels surprising given TOR on offense seemed to help.

The chart highlights the outlier turnover ratio of McNeese, who will be a tricky matchup.

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Former champs are all over the map for blocks, nothing conclusive there.

Straight away we see McNeese again avoiding blocks well, which we established as a strong signal.

Other notable teams who avoid blocks include, the Zags, Nova, Purdue, Houston, Miami OH, UF.

